

Shooting stars

A flash of light briefly streaks across the sky, and then disappears. It is probably a meteor – a common sight. Meteors are also known as shooting stars.



Fragments of Canon Diablo meteorite from the Barringer Crater in Arizona, USA.



What is it?

A meteor is a short-lived streak of light produced by a piece of space dust – a meteoroid – burning up as it speeds through the Earth's atmosphere. This happens about 90 km (56 miles) above the ground. A piece of space rock that survives the journey and lands on the Earth is called a meteorite.



Sparkling showers

When several fragments of a former comet or asteroid enter the Earth's atmosphere and burn up, it can result in spectacular showers. One famous shower takes place every November, when the Earth passes through a swarm of meteoroids known as the Leonids.

Bomb blast

When the Wolf Creek meteorite crater was formed 1–2 million years ago it exploded like an atomic bomb. Nearly a perfect circle, the crater is 853 m (2,798 ft) in diameter.

Wolf Creek Crater
Great Sandy Desert, Western Australia

